

crop type, cropping history of the field, soil health, irrigation, and how and when it is applied. “The more data we have, the better decisions farmers and other stakeholders can make.”

However, what remained unaddressed by both was why such trials did not precede the widespread adoption.

### POTENCY CHALLENGED

In another unusual move, another FCO published on March 9, 2026, cut the nano-fertiliser dose, raising doubts about its efficacy in supplying nutrients.

“Package of Practice must contain the crop-wise basal dose of 75% RDF (Recommended Dose of Fertiliser) with 25% dose of nano fertiliser as per the trial’s positive outcome,” the notification said.

This is a climbdown from the IFFCO protocol, which all field trials have followed until now; 50% basal dose of RDF and 50% of nano fertiliser. This is particularly true for nano urea liquid. Urea accounts for 60% of total fertiliser use and is a major source of nitrogen, a macronutrient.

To understand the FCO directive, consider urea use for wheat or paddy.

A ‘basal dose’ of RDF means the first dose of conventional granular urea applied to the soil at the time of sowing, constituting 50% of total urea use. Nano urea is meant to replace the rest 50% of conventional urea (applied before flowering); it is applied to the foliage (not soil) in two sprays from a 500 ml bottle.

The IFFCO protocol came in 2021, after nano fertilis-



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## THE NANO STORY

In 2021, the Centre allowed the commercial production of nano urea, which it claimed was “revolutionary and game changing”

It claimed the drive would make India self-reliant, end fertiliser imports by 2025 and raise yields and nutritional quality of crops

Six years later, India is staring at a fertiliser supply constraint due to the war in West Asia

An FCO order published March 13, 2026, directed stopping the use of nano fertilisers through forced sale to farmers

IFFCO, inventor and manufacturer of nano fertilisers, denies forced selling, and assures that it would implement the FCO directive